

Developer vs. Architect

How do the roles of a software developer compare to those of a software architect?

CATEGORY	SOFTWARE DEVELOPER	SOFTWARE ARCHITECT
PRIMARY FOCUS	Deep focus on one component, feature, or module; works at the “little picture” level	Broad, systemic understanding of the entire system; thinks at the “big picture” level across many components
SCOPE OF RESPONSIBILITY	Responsible for delivering code and features within their assigned area	Responsible for how all components fit together, how changes ripple across the system, and how the entire architecture evolves
DEPTH VS BREADTH OF KNOWLEDGE	Deep expertise in specific technologies used within their assigned component	Broad understanding of many technologies, patterns, and systems; less depth in individual areas, but much wider coverage of areas of expertise
DECISION-MAKING	Makes local decisions that impact their own module or team	Evaluates, guides, influences, and often makes system-wide decisions that impact multiple teams across a larger organization
INTERACTION WITH TEAMS	Works primarily with their direct team or immediate collaborators	Collaborates across engineering, operations, product management, and sometimes executive leadership
MINDSET	Problem solver at the implementation level, focuses on immediate technical issues	Systemic thinker. Anticipates long-term impact, tradeoffs, and organization alignment
MENTORSHIP ROLE	Mentors junior engineers, often through code reviews and pair programming	Actively trains, coaches, and grows the entire team’s technical maturity; often seen as an extension of management; has responsibilities to ensure entire team uplevels to meet changing architecture demands

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CATEGORY	SOFTWARE DEVELOPER	SOFTWARE ARCHITECT
APPROACH TO DECISION GUIDANCE	Provides input on local questions	Guides developers to make decisions that are good for the system as a whole; not dictating, but teaching
TECHNICAL DEBT	May create or uncover technical debt locally	Owns responsibility for the system's overall technical debt posture and ensures decisions reduce long-term cost appropriately
EVALUATION	Gets reviews of their designs and code. Provides feedback on designs and code of other developers	Reviews designs created by developers. Evaluates architectural impact. Regularly provides team evaluation input to management and/or participates in review processes
LEARNING & SKILL DEVELOPMENT	Learns tools and technologies needed for their assignments	Must continually learn new technologies, patterns, and industry practices that might impact future architectural direction, even if not immediately needed for current projects
OPERATIONAL AWARENESS	May or may not have operational involvement for their specific component	Responsible for understanding and designing for scale, availability, performance, and operational reliability
AUTHORITY VS INFLUENCE	Relies primarily on technical skill and individual contribution	Relies on influence, persuasion, teaching, and leadership; unlike management, authority comes from clarity and trust, not command
WORK STYLE	Builds software, delivers features, implement changes	Guides, evaluates, approves, trains, mentors, communicates, and ensures architectural consistency and direction